

IT IS TIME TO GIVE

TEXT: Malachi 3:8-11 *“Will a mere mortal rob God? Yet you rob me. “But you ask, ‘How are we robbing you?’ “In tithes and offerings. You are under a curse—your whole nation—because you are robbing me. Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house. Test me in this,” says the Lord Almighty, “and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven and pour out so much blessing that there will not be room enough to store it. I will prevent pests from devouring your crops, and the vines in your fields will not drop their fruit before it is ripe,” says the Lord Almighty.”*

INTRO: God called withholding the tithe, robbery! I didn't call it that, God did! This is because they were in unlawful possession of what belonged to God. This is theft by receiving and not giving! Actually, everything belongs to God. Psalm 24:1 *“The earth is the Lord's, and*

all its fullness, The world and those who dwell therein.”

Everything belongs to God, yet, He is so generous that He allows us to keep 90% as managers on His behalf. The tithe is Holy to the Lord. They are not given to us to manage – they belong to what the Lord calls, “***My house.***” It is impossible to give our tithe to the Lord, we can only return it, because it never belonged to us to begin with! If it doesn’t belong to us and we refuse to return it, that makes us a thief.

Today, I want to explore three questions about giving:

CAN WE JUSTIFY GIVING OUR SIN TO GOD AND WITHHOLDING OUR WEALTH?

Why would we enthusiastically give God our sin and withhold our wealth?

Why would we gladly give him the worst, and begrudgingly give him the best?

Think of how we came to God:

- Lost...
- Guilty...
- Hurting...
- Used up...
- Washed up...

By the time we came to the Lord, the world and the enemy had used the battering ram of life and sin, to beat our brakes off! Right?

When we came to the Lord a great exchange was made! We traded dirty garments for robes of righteousness. We were the prodigal sons and daughters welcomed home by a forgiving Heavenly Father! The old song say's "*I gave Him my old tattered garments. He gave me a robe of pure white. I'm feasting just now on His manna, and that's why I'm happy tonight.*"

We cannot justify giving God our sin while withholding our wealth! It is time to give!

HOW CAN WE GLADLY RECEIVE FROM GOD AND NOT GLADLY GIVE TO GOD?

Those who are against tithing, resist on the basis of self-interest. Self-interest often is masqueraded with statements like:

- Tithing is an Old Testament principle...
Tithing actually predates the Law of Moses!
Abraham gave tithe to Melchizedec.
- I don't believe in tithing - I believe in generosity... Perfect! Feel free to give beyond the 10%! Tithing doesn't make us generous, it makes us compliant! (Susan and I give 40%) Winston Churchill said, "*We make a living by what we get. We make a life by what we give.*"

Ladies and gentlemen, everything we have comes from Father God. His intention is, that we get to enjoy some of it, and some of it we

must sow. The law of the harvest is that those who sow, reap! Those who don't sow have no basis for an expectation of a harvest!

We must sow with the right attitude! 2 Corinthians 9:7 (NKJV) *“So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver.”* It is God who loves a cheerful giver! We will accept your offering no matter what your attitude is when you give it. H. Jackson Brown Jr. said, *“The happiest people are not those who are getting more, but those who are giving more.”*

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**IF GOD GAVE HIS BEST SACRIFICE,
WHY WOULD WE THINK IT PROPER
TO GIVE HIM A LAME SACRIFICE?**

God gave a sacrifice for us, and His name is Jesus. Jesus was not a lame sacrifice. He was the perfect sacrifice. If this is true, why would

we think God would accept a lame sacrifice from us?

The sacrifice offered from the Father was the without spot, without wrinkle, without blemish! The best, the perfect, the sinless sacrifice. Why would we even consider bringing anything but our best to Him?

Think of this in terms of going to a party where there is going to be a gift exchange. The host sets a limit on what is to be spent on the gift. This is done so that the guests will not be embarrassed by the quality of the gift that they are offering for the exchange. The same is true here! God gave His best – We should give our best!

Many people with financial problems fail to do the most important thing first—obey and honor God with their resources. If you ask me to pray for your finances I will certainly do so, but I am going to first ask you, “*Are you a tither?*” I am

powerless to pray off of you a self-inflicted curse. You can't pray that off, you must break the curse with obedience.

If we give our best with a good attitude, God will make sure that we are not disappointed with what He gives to us.

The words of Malachi are strong words, because this is the last thing God was going to say for 400 years. These words are parting instructions! Parting words are important words! (Guy who asked his attorney and banker to be at his deathbed – *“My Lord died between two thieves – I am not better than my Lord.”*)

As the curtains come down on the Old Testament God wanted to make sure that people took seriously, the issue of ownership and stewardship.

Giving and financial management are not only financial issues, they are more importantly spiritual issues.

Money is the only place where the Lord commanded the people to TEST Him. He basically said: “***See if you can give to me and be the poorer for it!***” He was saying: “***Try outgiving me, I double-dog dare you!***”

St. Francis of Assisi said, “*It is in giving that we receive.*”

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CONCLUSION:

Notice what God said His response to our giving would be. Provision and protection.

- 1) Provision: “***I will open the floodgates of heaven and pour you out blessings that you won’t have room to store it all.***” Returning the 10% to God also invokes a blessing upon

the 90% that we get to keep. Withholding the 10% brings a curse on the whole 100%!

- 2) Protection: ***“I will rebuke the devourer for your sake.”*** Tithing teaches us to put God first, and it demonstrates TRUST in a Heavenly Father that has resources that we don’t even know about. (My experience with learning to release God to ***“Rebuke the devourer for my sake.”***)

Anne Frank said, *“No one has ever become poor by giving.”*